

Harpagophytum procumbens (Pedaliaceae)

Devil's Claw

The colorful name of this African plant is derived from the appearance of its tough, barbed fruit. The medicinal properties of devil's claw were first discovered by various southern African peoples, who used a decoction of the tuber to treat digestive problems and arthritis. The herb is now widely available in pharmacies and health food stores in the West as a remedy for arthritis and rheumatism.



Devil's claw, found growing in the Transvaal, has bright purple flowers in spring.

Habitat & Cultivation

Devil's claw is native to Namibia, Botswana, and South Africa, where it is a protected species due to over-harvesting of wild plants. It thrives in clay or sandy soils, preferring roadsides and open areas, especially places where natural vegetation has been cleared. Propagated from seed in spring, the young tubers are unearthed in autumn and cut into pieces about $\frac{3}{4}$ in (2 cm) long. Care is taken not to mix the tubers, which contain the active constituents, with the roots, as this can render the herb ineffective.

Related Species

Two related species, both growing in Africa, are used medicinally in a more or less similar way to devil's claw.

Key Constituents

- Iridoid glycosides (harpagoside)
- Sugars (stachyose)
- Phytosterols
- Flavonoids

Key Actions

- Anti-inflammatory
- Analgesic
- Digestive stimulant
- Antiarthritic

Research

■ **Anti-inflammatory** French research (1992) indicated that devil's claw is anti-inflammatory, but opinion is divided on its effectiveness in practice.

■ **Pain relief** There is some evidence to confirm devil's claw's use as an analgesic as it seems to be effective in easing the symptoms of joint pain.

■ **Bitter** The strongly bitter action of devil's claw stimulates and tones the digestive system. Many arthritic conditions are associated with poor digestion and absorption of food, and the stimulant effect of this herb on the stomach and gallbladder contributes to its overall therapeutic value as an antiarthritic remedy.

Traditional & Current Uses■ **African traditional remedy**

Devil's claw is used by various peoples in southern Africa, including the Khoisan and the Bantu. Traditionally it has been used as a tonic, especially for digestive problems; for arthritis and rheumatism; to reduce fevers; and as an ointment for sores, ulcers, and boils.

■ **Western uses** Current Western use of devil's claw is broadly in line with its traditional application. It is commonly available over the counter in tablet form for arthritic and rheumatic conditions and can bring

Devil's claw

A trailing perennial, reaching 5 ft (1.5 m) in length, with fleshy lobed leaves and barbed, woody fruit.

**Parts Used**

Tuber is harvested in autumn and used in a variety of antiarthritic preparations.



Chopped dried tuber



Sliced dried tuber

Key Preparations & Their Uses

⚠ **Cautions** Do not take if suffering from gallstones or peptic ulcer. Do not take during pregnancy. May interact with anticoagulants.



Decoction (to make, p. 291).
For rheumatism, simmer 1 tsp root in $\frac{3}{4}$ cup (150 ml) water for 15 minutes. Take in small doses over 1–2 days.



Tincture (to make, p. 292).
For arthritis associated with poor digestion, take 30 drops with water twice daily.



Tablets Take for arthritis and rheumatism.

relief from pain arising from a range of joint and muscular problems, including gout, back pain, fibrositis, and rheumatoid arthritis.

Self-help Uses

- Arthritis & inflamed joints, p. 313.
- Back pain due to joint inflammation, p. 313.